

Men or Citizens

Actual consequences of a unconventional distinction established by Rousseau

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&1. Men and citizens

In the *Dedicace* of the famous *Discours sur l'Origine et les Fondements de l'Inégalité parmi les Hommes* (1754), Jean Jacques Rousseau writes:

*If I had been able to choose the place of my birth ..., I would have chosen a well-governed society and in which, corresponding each one to his work, no one felt obliged to give to another the functions of which he was in charge (...). I would have wanted to be born in a country where the sovereign and the people could have but a single and same interest, so that all the movements of the social machine would never have for a purpose other than ordinary happiness (...) I would have wanted to choose for me a country driven away by a happy impotence of the terrible love of conquests (...). I would have sought a country where the right of legislation was common to all citizens because, who better than them, can know under what conditions they should live together in the same society? (...) That the providence to all this had added even a charming situation, a temperate climate, a fertile ground and a delightful landscape (...), nothing more would have wished to complete my happiness than to enjoy all these goods within this happy homeland (Rousseau, 1754, *Dedicace*, pp. 115-118, excerpts)*

Rousseau draws here, with the eloquence and elegance that are his own, the profile of a "happy homeland" in which he would have liked to have been born. It happens, however, that such a happy homeland does not exist and that, moreover, neither Rousseau nor any of us chooses the place of his birth. Besides, none of us, at the time of birth, belong to any homeland. We are all stateless. We are all born in a world that is

strange to us. We are all born naked, unprotected, dependent, savage, infinitely poor. We are all immigrants, outsiders, foreigners, "*new human beings*", "newcomers by birth" as Hannah Arendt (1961: 37 and 25) says. "*New by birth and by nature*", we land in a world that we have not choose and know nothing about, "an old world, that is, a pre-existing world, built by the living and the dead, a world that is only new to those who have recently entered it by *immigration*" (Arendt, 1961: 25 and 27). We. All of us!

Foreigners, immigrants, stateless persons, how do we become citizens? Insensibly, subtly, slowly, we are becoming adapted. After a few years, we speak our mother's tongue. Our gestures become predictable. We know the rules of the group in which we were welcomed (or collected), the rules of the aggregate, the laws of the club, the values of the tribe. We acquire the habits of our parents. We are integrated. We are civilized! We are educated! About 18 years after we were born, naked and stateless, we are granted the status of full citizens. We are decisively removed from our original status as newcomers, foreigners, immigrants, refugees. We are now citizens, full members of a certain state. More and more early, by the way, states are rushing to recognize humans who have just been born as citizens. As soon as we are born – naked, undifferentiated, "some any", as Agamben (1990: 11) would say – not knowing yet neither family, state, nation, language or religion, with no place, no belonging, absolutely fragile and helpless, we are given a citizen card. How to explain this early allocation of citizen status by modern states? Because, in the logic of the state, what matters is that there are citizens, that is, individuals who pay taxes and secure the electoral base on which, by definition of the democratic state itself, sovereignty resides.

In a brilliant book entitled *Cholera and Time* (2006), Sloterdijk identifies a founding episode of the passage from man to citizen. He argues that ancient Greece was the scene of a psychological transmutation of immense political importance in the future. It was when Homer transforms the epic rage of Achilles into the measured courage of Ulysses. Achilles, the furious hero, proud, "irreducible as the storm and the sunlight" (Sloterdijk, 2006: 16), ends up sacrificed. The great winner of the Trojan war is Ulysses, the crafty, the cunning, the sly, the moderate, the discreet. He wisely realizes the figure of the "rational animal" that Greek philosophy will constitute as the fundamental determination of the human. He announces the sedentary and prudent farmer, the urban

artisan, the professor of rhetoric and dialectic, the skilled politician, the public agent, in a word, the citizen. Soon cholera will be a pathology, pride will be a sin, the capacity for indignation will be repressed. In their times, forgiveness, humility and obedience will make their entry into the list of virtues that the citizen must incarnate. A citizen who, as a domesticated figure, will be limited, centuries later, to depositing his/her vote, of so many in so many years, in the "ballot box" of the voting section, corresponding to his "number" of "citizen-elect" in the neighbourhood of his residence of the city in which he/she lives. Democracy will be then reduced to this orderly ceremony in which every citizen is only expected to deposit, in so many and so many years, his/her (secret) vote at the electoral ballot box. Perhaps it is not by chance that schools - (ideological) apparatus with a decisive role in the organization of the state - are too often the places chosen for this submissive ceremony of a democracy reduced to its minimal functioning. The location of the "urn" in a classroom intensifies the funeral symbolism of the electoral act since the school is a decisive partner of the state in this operation that, in limit, elides the man and values the citizen.

But let us go back to Rousseau. The French revolution had not yet happened when Rousseau wrote the *Discours sur l'Origine et les Fondements de l'Inégalité parmi les Hommes* (1754). And, if Rousseau was indeed one of the most important figures for the theoretical foundation of the French revolution (Robespierre was not mistaken when he went to his abandoned grave in the *Ille des Peupliers* and took his remains in triumph to the *Panthéon* in Paris, where it remains as the only non-French celebrated figure) the truth is that Rousseau would never have agreed to the title of the declaration approved by the National Constituent Assembly in October 1789. I am referring to the celebrated *Declaration of Human and Citizen Rights*, the 17 articles of which are the fundamental inspiration for the subsequent *Universal Declaration of Human Rights* adopted by the United Nations on 10 December 1948.

Rousseau could never accept the identification between man and citizen that such title encloses. In referring to the rights of the "man" and the "citizen", the *Declaration* of 1789 thinks out of man and citizen as identical realities, equivalent, necessarily united. And the content of the 17 articles that make up the celebrated *Declaration* leaves no room for doubt about this identification. Now, for Rousseau (long before Sloterdijk),

there is a decisive opposition between Man and Citizen. As he writes on the front pages of his pedagogical romance the *Émile*: "*It is necessary to choose between making a Man or a Citizen because one cannot, at the same time, do one and the other*"

For Rousseau, the citizen opposes man, both from an anthropological point of view, as well as socially and political. The citizen is the degenerate man, vanquished, forced to abandon his original innocence, constrained to replace his primitive inclinations with strange and relative duties. A man who has lost his identity, his integrity, his condition of being whole, the right to his proper name: "*a citizen of Rome is neither Gaius nor Lucius but a Roman*". That is why it is not possible to form a man who is at the same time a citizen. It is impossible to accomplish both at the same time. It is necessary to choose. Therefore, the fate of education is outlined. It will be negative. Its task will be to prevent contagion. What should we do to educate a man? Rousseau asks a little further. And he answers: "*Very, without a doubt: to prevent anything from being done.*"

We know that the *Émile* (1762), the *Discours sur l'Origine et les Fondements de l'Inégalité parmi les Hommes* (1754), (1754) and the *Contrat Social* (1762), constitute the theoretical nucleus of Rousseau's philosophical system. They are three central works that had a huge impact on their time, which unleashed passions, which were idolized by some and detested by others, arrested and persecuted. With violence like few throughout our history, they have been condemned, confiscated, banned, burned. The *Émile* was denounced at the Sorbonne, condemned by parliament, confiscated by the police, burned in Paris and, following its publication, its author, Rousseau himself, was subject of an arrest warrant that will force him to live as a fugitive and to hid, first, in Switzerland, and then in England.

We also know that, beyond the immense influence he has had over the centuries and all that we owe him in terms of understanding and respect for childhood, the *Émile* by Rousseau was very poorly read in our time, claimed as an inspiring source of the most absurd and foolish pedagogical consequences. But we cannot fail to recognize that the *Émile* was very well read in his day precisely by those who condemned him. Rousseau's contemporaries who sentenced the *Émile* or who supported this condemnation, quickly understood that they could not accept the distinction there established between man and citizen. They quickly and well guessed the political consequences that such distinction announces. The devaluation of the citizen that this

distinction entails would jeopardize their most secret yearnings. The condemnation that the *Émile* was targeted of, has indeed, at its origin, the fact that, among other reasons, the work went against the general longing of Rousseau's contemporaries: to become citizens. They wished that their lives would cease to be dependent on real power, a power of divine origin, an absolute and discretionary power. On the contrary, they wished only to be accountable to a new type of state that they were preparing to form and which would be founded on the recognition that sovereignty resides, not in the sovereigns, but in the governed. They wanted to stop being subjects and to become citizens. Further, they wanted all men to be citizens, equal in rights and freedoms. The principle of equality which they proclaimed as the basis of the new secular law which they intended to build could only be applied if all men, beyond their differences as men, were recognised in their equal status as citizens. That is to say, the Rousseau's contemporaries who condemned the *Émile* could not understand Rousseau's anticipatory, visionary and accurate criticism against the domesticating, normalizing, controlling effects that would be later exercised on the lives of men by the state they were preparing to constitute and that appeared to all (the non-aristocrats, the ascendant bourgeoisie) as a solution to the injustices and arbitrariness of the *ancient régime*.

Likewise, today we are not indifferent to the opposition established by Rousseau between man and citizen. It appears to us as bizarre, excessive, extravagant. Beyond the discussion about the meaning of this opposition within Rousseau's system, this opposition directly hurts some of our deepest beliefs. If so: what is man? What is the citizen? What are social and political life? What is social morality? What is education? Moreover, it disturbs our awareness of good citizens. Is it because I am a man that I have the rights of man and citizen? Or, on the contrary, as some think (as some dangerously tend to say explicitly nowadays), is it because I am a citizen that I have human rights?

It is certain that the *Universal Declaration of Human Rights* adopted by the UN shortly after the second world war refers in its title solely to "human rights". The word citizen, which was present in the French *Declaration of Human and Citizen Rights* of 1789, disappears. But, in fact, the *Universal Declaration* does delete the word citizen because it accepts the distinction made by Rousseau between men and citizens and, on that basis, addresses men, that is, all men, as the adjective "universal" seems to indicate? Or, on

the contrary, does it confuse the two concepts in such a way, does it think them in such a way as indistinct, that, therefore, in addressing men, it is indifferently addressing men "and" citizens? Or is it - and this is the worst-case scenario - directed only at men who are citizens, who have the status of citizens? Unfortunately, there are some today who stress: it is because I am a citizen, it is because I am covered by the civil rights of a particular state where I pay my taxes, that I have human rights. On the contrary, those who do not pay taxes, those who are not citizens, those who do not have any state that represents and defends them, those who are merely men, they must not have no right at all. Rousseau had clearly foreseen this perverse consequence of the non-distinction between man and citizen. As he writes in an admirably accurate form also in the *Émile*: *"Every patriot is hard towards foreigners: they are nothing but men, they are nothing in their eyes"*.

Thus, the opposition formulated by Rousseau between man and citizen appears as very relevant and as having today an immense impact. In the face of the current massive phenomenon of immigration, the entry into Europe and some other rich countries in the northern hemisphere of thousands and thousands (millions) of immigrants and refugees, this opposition screams the internal contradiction to the concepts of human rights and citizen that Rousseau has anticipated.

The emigrant, the refugee is someone who has left everything, who has left his country, who has left his family, who has separated from his friends, who will never see his city, his neighbourhood, his street, his home, which has lost everything except his quality as a human. It should therefore be a privileged object and absolutely protected by human rights. But that is not what happens. What we are witnessing today is the explicit functioning of the effects, which Rousseau anticipated, of the non-distinction between man and citizen. Only this indistinction and the consequent reversal of Rousseau's thesis - not to pay attention to man, and only to value the citizen - can justify the drama that is currently being lived on the borders of rich countries, the desperate attempts to overcome the walls, the arrival in precarious boats to the beaches of Europe, the tragic shipwrecks in the Mediterranean, the fields to which thousands and thousands of individuals who are men but are not citizens are thrown.

Or rather, they are men who, because they are not citizens, they are not recognized as deserving to have human rights.

&2. About the so-called “education for citizenship”

The opposition established by Rousseau between man and citizen questions in a radical way our traditional conception of school, largely born with the French revolution. It questions the concept of school – now considered indisputable, obvious, politically correct – according to which it is up to the school to prepare all the young people who franchise its door for the informed and responsible exercise of citizenship, that is, to prepare men to be citizens. And in this process, many argue, it is up to the "education for citizenship" to play a decisive role.

As Europeans, we are living today in a new and unexpected situation. We are currently being invaded by thousands and thousands of immigrants, refugees, many illegal people without a passport that have abandoned their homeland, escaping the war or just looking for a better life. People that, better or worse, we receive, we house, we employ, we try to integrate.

This situation has an immense impact on our schools. It puts an end to the traditional homogeneity of our pupils, with all its positive and negative consequences. Beyond the marginals, the marginalized, the inhabitants of degraded neighbourhoods, the children of unemployed, almost illiterate parents who still exist in our developed societies, today, also the children of immigrants, refugees and foreigners attend our schools. And teachers are asked the task of making citizens of them as well. Not only to honorably teach them, or, in a more humanistic version, not only to improve their condition as men (that is, to educate them), but to make them citizens of the particular state (our own) that has received them. The so-called “Education for Citizenship” finds here - many argue - the deepest foundation for the absolute urgency of its curricular inclusion in our education system.

A central issue now has to be addressed: face to the recent presence of foreigners attending our schools, face to thousands immigrants who sit in our classrooms, in what may consist the so-called "education for citizenship?" How is it possible? What aporias run through it? To what extent can we (or, have we the right) to impose on these foreigners, on these refugees, on these immigrants, an education for citizenship marked

by our nationality? And to what extent should we (can we) practice an education for citizenship that respects the nationalities of these immigrants, of these refugees, of these foreigners?

Let me generalize and broaden the question: should (can) education for citizenship aim at a true pluralism of values, knowledges, access to different cultural forms? Or are we doomed to reproduce our own cultural idiosyncrasy, our way of life, our perspective on the world?

Three solutions are configured. The first is a negationist one. As Bourdieu (1970) and Bernstein (1990) would say – just to mention two of the most significant names in the sociology of the old continent school - we are always reproducing, that is, we are always excluding, going over, imposing our ways of seeing, of thinking, of feeling. We impose our gestures, our habits, our moral norms, our rules of conduct and our etiquette. We impose *our* culture, *our curricula*, our literature. Camões, Proust, Joyce, Calvin have no universal value. They are great poets only, and respectively, for the Portuguese, the French, the Irish, the Italians. If we were Pakistanis, Moroccans, Libyans or Ukrainians, we would not know Camões, Proust, Joyce or Calvino, just as most probably we do not know the poets of Pakistan, Morocco, Libya or Ukraine. We impose our western science, our home-made, cultural, contextual mathematics. If we were Eskimos, inhabitants of African deserts or Aborigines, people of distant, strange regions designed in our civilized maps, we would have other medicines, other descriptions of the charts of the stars, very different ways of understanding the body. That is, we are condemned to always teach our national culture. We always tend to impose our national views and values. We impose our culture and our science and we impose ourselves. And that is without medicine and without forgiveness.

The second solution is dictated by multiculturalism. We resolutely make the naïve and well-intentioned decision to meet the particularities of the culture of the new, foreign students. We try hard to respect their culture, their traditions, their values, their way of seeing the world. As we have Pakistani, Ukrainian, African, Brazilian, Russian, Chinese, Bangladeshi students, we mix all we can get of those cultures and stay well with our conscience. Animated by a true good will, and forgetting our complete lack of preparation for this task, we produce a "fruit salad" (Steiner, 2003: 127), an amalgam in which we try to gather a little of each of the cultures that we think we are capable of

understanding, without having any specific training or even knowing their respective languages.

The third solution may be considered affirmative or universalist. Neither a more or less chauvinistic nationalism, nor a multiculturalist pluralism. For a universal and cosmopolitan culture, as Kant would say. Solution that, in my view, involves at least six fundamental determinations.

First determination - to define as the task of the education for citizenship the development of citizens of the world. I am not talking about globalization, a term that is still very misleading, which corresponds both to the effective generalization of financial capital (without the corresponding generalization of human, civil and labor rights), and to a cultural uniformity according to audience standards that ultimately stem from the great media and advertising empires. I am referring to the great universal culture, which, although having its origin in a certain space and time, is of all times and of all spaces. Not, because those who claim themselves as direct heirs of the spaces and times of that universal culture are better, more perfect, superior in any dimension whatsoever. But because, in this particular space and time, at the mercy of the gathering of fragile circumstances, fundamental works were produced that, although unknown to many, can be loved by all. More specifically, what has been best produced throughout history in the field of science, the arts, philosophy. Here a passage from Bertrand Russell which illustrates well what I mean: *"Men pass from birth to death, sometimes happy, sometimes unhappy; sometimes generous, sometimes grasping and petty; sometimes heroic, sometimes cowardly and servile. To the man who views the procession as a whole, certain things stand out as worthy of admiration. Some men have been inspired by love of mankind, some by supreme intellect have helped us to understand the world in which we live, and some by exceptional sensitiveness have created beauty. These men have produced something of positive good to outweigh the long record of cruelty, oppression, and superstition. These men have done what lay in their power to make human life a better thing than the brief turbulence of savages"* (Russell, 1950: 153).

It is the results, the products, the works of these *"men worthy of admiration"* that could (should) constitute a matter of an education for citizenship, truly committed at the formation of the citizen of the World.

Second determination - to bet on the school (and the University for the most reason) as a place of transmission of this universal culture. Do not be afraid to teach Camões, Proust, James Joyce, or Calvino. Of course, if we were Pakistanis or Ukrainians, or Libyans, we would not probably know Camões, Proust, James Joyce, or Calvino, just as we do not know the great poets and writers of Pakistan, Ukraine, Libya or Russia. Not, because we could not (or should not) know and love the great writers of these countries. But because we would not have had a chance to learn and to love them. In limit, we would not know and love those poets and writers for lack of school and lack of universal culture that the school is responsible for giving to all those who franchise its doors. Why would not a Portuguese, or a French, or a Spanish or an Italian young boy and girl be able to read, and learn, and study, and love Puskin, Tolstoy, Dostoyevsky, Tchekov, Gogol, Nabukov, Pasternak? Why would not a Russian student be able to read and learn, and study, and love Pessoa, Balzac, Cervantes or Primo Levy?

Third determination - not to be afraid of the universality of culture. Even if this culture was born in the West, as it is the case with science. Forgive me for venting. But it is embarrassing to see what is going on at this level. As if there was one western science and one that was not. As if there was a western mathematics and one that was not. One must be aware that, if Euclid had not written the *Elements*, if Newton had not formulated the law of universal attraction, if Darwin had not defended the theory of evolution, if Freud had not invented the unconscious, others, with other names, with other nationalities, more or less at the same time, would have come to these results and conjecture these same hypotheses. The theory of relativity would have been enunciated. And Einstein's formula would be identical.

What I am saying is that – as difficult and bizarre and extravagant as this may seem to our (bad) conscience of former colonialists who want now to redeem their sins by handing over to falsely progressive relativism – science is universal. Science is an heritage of all men, white, black, yellow, poor, and rich, wealthy or miserable. It was initiated in the West, not because the West was the homeland of the best, or the place chosen by the gods, but because it was in the West, more precisely in the jagged hills of the Greek soil, that, for the first time, a set of fundamental conditions necessary for its development (fundamentally, the alphabetical writing and the democracy) were reunite. Beyond all territorial demarcations, all national interests, all the differences between

practices, laboratories, universities, associations, behind all the secrets with which many today want to circumscribe the universal sharing of their results, science is of us all, a collective activity, a collaborative work between peers and between generations. It is certain that their theorems, their laws and theories almost always refer to a particular name. But they are everyone's.

To whom do Mendel's laws belong? They are currently being taught in every school, from Tokyo to Berlin, from Singapore to Lisbon, from Casablanca to Montevideo. To whom belong the law of the falling bodies? It was discovered by Galileo but it belongs to all mankind. There are nowadays articles published in the major international science journals which are signed by overweening extensive research teams from various nationalities. There are universities all over the world increasingly offering interdisciplinary programs to increasingly international groups of students. There are universities in Europe as in China, Africa or America where the same mathematics and the same chemistry are taught and learned.

Fourth determination - to bet on the School (and the University for the most reason) as a place of broad, comprehensive, wide understanding of the world. In the words, once again, of B. Russell, the citizen of the world should be: *"aware of his own insignificance and of his environment closest to the world, both in terms of time and space. You should see your own country, not just as your home, but as a country among other countries, all of them with the same right to live, think and feel. You should be able to situate your own time in relation to the past and the future, to be aware that the controversies that surround you today will seem as foreign to future generations as those of the past now seem to us. From an even broader perspective, you should become aware of the vastness of the geological eras and the abyssal astronomical distances. However, the awareness of all this should not function as a burden capable of crushing the individual man, but rather as a vast panorama that widens the spirit of those who contemplate him"* (Russell, 1950: 78).

A whole teaching program – from History, Geography, Philosophy, Geology, Astronomy – is designed here and put at the service of widening perspectives, of expanding horizon, of comprehensive openness to the immense and diverse world that surrounds us.

Fifth determination - to bet on the school (and the University) as the place for a polyglot teaching. To impose, force, compel all children to study 2, 3, 4 languages. To require, obligate, coerce all university students to read and study in several languages. Not to be limited to *basic* English. Learning a language is conquering a new point of view on the world. It is opening another window of the soul. Moreover, learning one language is, as Steiner says (2003: 128-129), reducing "disdain for the other". In this sense – I ask – the learning of the languages of the foreigners who live in our cities, of the immigrants living next door, refugees, illegals, those who do not have a passport, would it not be a beautiful way of giving cognitive consistency to a rich education for citizenship?

Sixth determination – to empty the programs and the teaching of the education for citizenship of any normative or moralizing claim. Prevent, as Russell says, any resemblance to propaganda: *"To the propagandist [teacher], his pupils are potential soldiers in an army. They are to serve purposes that lie outside their own lives, not in the sense in which every generous purpose transcends self, but in the sense of ministering to unjust privilege or to despotic power. The propagandist does not desire that his pupils should survey the world and freely choose a purpose to them appears of value* (Russell, 1950: 79).

Russell is even more explicit about the need for the teacher to refuse uplifting moralism in the following passage: *"In most countries, certain opinions are recognized as correct, and others as dangerous. Teachers whose opinions are not correct are expected to keep silent about them. If they mention their opinions it is propaganda while the mentioning of correct opinions is considered to be merely sound instruction (...). There is in America a subject called civics in which, perhaps more than any other, the teaching is expected to be misleading. The young are taught a sort of copy book account of how public affairs are supposed to be conducted, and are carefully shielded from all knowledge as to how in fact they are conducted. When they grow up and discover the truth, the result is too often a complete cynicism in which all public ideals are lost; whereas, if they had been taught the truth carefully and with proper comment at an earlier age they might have become men able to combat evils in which, as it is, they acquiesce with shrug. The idea that falsehood is edifying is one of the besetting sins of those who draw up educational schemes. I should not myself consider that a man could*

be a good teacher unless he had made a firm resolve never, in the course of his teaching, to conceal because it is what is called "unedifying" (Russell, 1950: 156-157).

&1. Conclusive remarks

Let me end with one more quotation, now from H. Arendt. When one wants to educate children to belonging to a particular political society, even if utopian, *what is really happening is that "they we are actually denied their own future role in the body politic, for, from the standpoint of the new ones, whatever newt the adult world may propose is necessarily older than they themselves. It is in the nature of the human condition that each new generation grows into an old world, so that to prepare a new generation for a new world can only mean that one wishes to strike from the newcomers' hands their own chane at the new (Arendt (1961: 177).*

In limit, what Hannah Arendt is saying is that the school should not prepare for the tasks of the future because we do not know - nor should we want to know - what the future will be. What we must do is to give the newcomers the access to the "old world", the great universal culture that past generations have created. That only will give them the opportunity of making the difference in the "new world" from their primordial condition of foreigners and immigrants.

Rousseau, H. Arendt and B. Russell – are arguably great spirits. Arendt, an eternal foreigner and immigrant. Russell, an eloquent example of what a citizen of the world can be. Rousseau someone who, with an out-of-fashion radical view, calls into question everything we have today as obvious about what is men and what is citizen and therefore, what can be the education of the foreigners, the immigrants, the refugees that we all are. Perhaps it is worth listening for a moment what they tell us about the so-called education for citizenship.

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